

'It's of no consequence probably,' I said. 'But I found it in rather an unusual place.'

'You won't tell me where?'

Rather childishly, I wouldn't.

He had his secrets. Well, I would have mine.

I was a little hurt that he had not confided in me more fully.

Chapter 26

I was in a strange mood when I mounted the pulpit that night.

The church was unusually full. I cannot believe that it was the prospect of Hawes preaching which had attracted so many. Hawes' sermons are dull and dogmatic. And if the news had got round that I was preaching instead, that would not have attracted them either. For my sermons are dull and scholarly. Neither, I am afraid, can I attribute it to devotion.

Everybody had come, I concluded, to see who else was there, and possibly to exchange a little gossip in the church porch afterwards.

Haydock was in church, which is unusual, and also Lawrence Redding. And, to my surprise, beside Lawrence I saw the white strained face of Hawes. Anne Protheroe was there, but she usually attends Evensong on Sundays, though I had hardly thought she would today. I was far more surprised to see Lettice. Church-going was compulsory on Sunday morning—Colonel Protheroe was adamant on that point—but I had never seen Lettice at evening service before.

Gladys Cram was there, looking rather blatantly young and healthy against a background of wizened spinsters, and I fancied that a dim figure at the end of the church, who had slipped in late, was Mrs Lestrangle.

I need hardly say that Mrs Price Ridley, Miss Hartnell, Miss Wetherby and Miss Marple were there in full force. All the village people were there, with hardly a single exception. I don't know when we have had such a crowded congregation.

Crowds are queer things. There was a magnetic atmosphere that night, and the first person to feel its influence was myself.

As a rule, I prepare my sermons beforehand. I am careful and conscientious over them, but no one is better aware than myself of their deficiencies.

Tonight I was of necessity preaching *ex tempore*, and as I looked down on the sea of upturned faces, a sudden madness entered my brain. I ceased to be in any sense a minister of God. I became an actor. I had an audience before me and I wanted to move that audience—and more, I felt the power to move it.

I am not proud of what I did that night. I am an utter disbeliever in the emotional revivalist spirit. Yet that night I acted the part of a raving, ranting evangelist.

I gave out my text slowly.

I am come to call not the righteous but the sinners to repentance.

I repeated it twice, and I heard my own voice, a resonant, ringing voice unlike the voice of the everyday Leonard Clement.

I saw Griselda from her front pew look up in surprise, and Dennis follow her example.

I held my breath for a moment or two, and then I let myself rip.

The congregation in that church were in a state of pent-up emotion, ripe to be played upon. I played upon them. I exhorted sinners to repentance. I lashed myself into a kind of emotional frenzy. Again and again I threw out a denouncing hand and reiterated the phrase:

‘I am speaking to *you*.’

And each time, from different parts of the church, a kind of sighing gasp went up.

Mass emotion is a strange and terrible thing.

I finished up with those beautiful and poignant words—perhaps the most poignant words in the whole Bible:

‘This very night shall thy soul be required of thee...’

It was a strange brief possession. When I got back to the Vicarage I was my usual faded, indeterminate self. I found Griselda rather pale. She slipped her arm through mine.

‘Len,’ she said. ‘You were rather terrible tonight. I—I didn’t like it. I’ve never heard you preach like that before.’

‘I don’t suppose you ever will again,’ I said, sinking down wearily on the sofa. I was tired.

‘What made you do it?’

‘A sudden madness came over me.’

‘Oh! it—it wasn’t something special?’

He went on:

‘When she turned into this road that evening, it was here she came—to this house.’

‘You haven’t said so before.’

‘I didn’t want to create talk. Six to seven isn’t my time for seeing patients, and everyone knows that. But you can take my word for it that she was here.’

‘She wasn’t here when I came for you, though. I mean when we discovered the body.’

‘No,’ he seemed perturbed. ‘She’d left—to keep an appointment.’

‘In what direction was the appointment? In her own house?’

‘I don’t know, Clement. On my honour, I don’t know.’

I believed him, but—

‘And supposing an innocent man is hanged?’ I said.

He shook his head.

‘No,’ he said. ‘No one will be hanged for the murder of Colonel Protheroe. You can take my word for that.’

But that is just what I could not do. And yet the certainty in his voice was very great.

‘No one will be hanged,’ he repeated.

‘This man, Archer—’

He made an impatient movement.

‘Hasn’t got brains enough to wipe his finger prints off the pistol.’

‘Perhaps not,’ I said dubiously.

Then I remembered something, and taking the little brownish crystal I had found in the wood from my pocket I held it out to him and asked him what it was.

‘H’m,’ he hesitated. ‘Looks like picric acid. Where did you find it?’

‘That,’ I replied, ‘is Sherlock Holmes’ secret.’

He smiled.

‘What is picric acid?’

‘Well, it’s an explosive.’

‘Yes, I know that, but it’s got another use, hasn’t it?’

He nodded.

‘It’s used medically—in solution for burns. Wonderful stuff.’

I held out my hand and rather reluctantly he handed it back to me.

I told him that I was worried about Hawes, and that I was anxious that he should get away for a real rest and change.

Something evasive came into his manner when I said this. His answer did not ring quite true.

'Yes,' he said slowly, 'I suppose that would be the best thing. Poor chap. Poor chap.'

'I thought you didn't like him.'

'I don't—not much. But I'm sorry for a lot of people I don't like.' He added, after a minute or two, 'I'm even sorry for Protheroe. Poor fellow—nobody ever liked him much. Too full of his own recitude and too self-assertive. It's an unlovable mixture. He was always the same—even as a young man.'

'I didn't know you knew him then?'

'Oh! yes. When he lived in Westmoreland, I had a practice not far away. That's a long time ago now. Nearly twenty years.'

I sighed. Twenty years ago Griselda was five years old. Time is an odd thing.

'Is that all you came to say to me, Clement?'

I looked up with a start. Haydock was watching me with keen eyes.

'There's something else, isn't there?' he said.

I nodded.

I had been uncertain whether to speak or not when I came in, but now I decided to do so. I like Haydock as well as any man I know. He is a splendid fellow in every way. I felt that what I had to tell might be useful to him.

I recited my interviews with Miss Hartnell and Miss Wetherby.

He was silent for a long time after I'd spoken.

'It's quite true, Clement,' he said at last. 'I've been trying to shield Mrs Lestrangle from any inconvenience that I could. As a matter of fact, she's an old friend. But that's not my only reason. That medical certificate of mine isn't the put-up job you all think it was.'

He paused and then said gravely:

'This is between you and me, Clement. Mrs Lestrangle is doomed.'

'What?'

'She's a dying woman. I give her a month at longest. Do you wonder that I want to keep her from being badgered and questioned?'

'What do you mean—something special?'
'I wondered—that was all. You're very unexpected, Len. I never feel I really know you.'

We sat down to cold supper, Mary being out.

'There's a note for you in the hall,' said Griselda. 'Get it, will you, Dennis?'

Dennis, who had been very silent, obeyed.

I took it and groaned. Across the top left-hand corner was written, *By hand—Urgent*.

'This,' I said, 'must be from Miss Marple. There's no one else left.' I had been perfectly correct in my assumption.

Dear Mr Clement,

I should so much like to have a little chat with you about one or two things that have occurred to me. I feel we should all try and help in elucidating this sad mystery. I will come over about half past nine, if I may, and tap on your study window. Perhaps dear Griselda would be so very kind as to run over here and cheer up my nephew. And Mr Dennis too, of course, if he cares to come. If I do not hear, I will expect them and will come over myself at the time I have stated.

Yours very sincerely,

JANE MARPLE.

I handed the note to Griselda.

'Oh! we'll go,' she said cheerfully. 'A glass or two of homemade liqueur is just what one needs on Sunday evening. I think it's Mary's blanc mange that is so frightfully depressing. It's like something out of a mortuary.'

Dennis seemed less charmed at the prospect.

'It's all very well for you,' he grumbled. 'You can talk all this high brow stuff about art and books. I always feel a perfect fool sitting and listening to you.'

'That's good for you,' said Griselda serenely. 'It puts you in your place. Anyway I don't think Mr Raymond West is so frightfully clever as he pretends to be.'

'Very few of us are,' I said.

I wondered very much what exactly it was that Miss Marple wished to talk over. Of all the ladies in my congregation, I consider her by far the shrewdest. Not only does she see and hear practically everything that goes on, but she draws amazingly neat and apposite deductions from the facts that come under her notice.

If I were at any time to set out on a career of deceit, it would be of Miss Marple that I should be afraid.

What Griselda called the Nephew Amusing Party started off at a little after nine, and while I was waiting for Miss Marple to arrive I amused myself by drawing up a kind of schedule of the facts connected with the crime. I arranged them so far as possible in chronological order. I am not a punctual person, but I am a neat one, and I like things jotted down in a methodical fashion.

At half past nine punctually, there was a little tap on the window and I rose and admitted Miss Marple.

She had a very fine Shetland shawl thrown over her head and shoulders, and was looking rather old and frail. She came in full of little fluttering remarks.

'So good of you to let me come—and so good of dear Griselda—Raymond admires her so much—the perfect Greuze he always calls her. Shall I sit here? I am not taking your chair? Oh! thank you. No, I won't have a footstool.'

I deposited the Shetland shawl on a chair and returned to take a chair facing my guest. We looked at each other, and a little deprecating smile broke out on her face.

'I feel that you must be wondering why—why I am so interested in all this. You may possibly think it's very unwomanly. No—please—I should like to explain if I may.'

She paused a moment, a pink colour suffusing her cheeks.

'You see,' she began at last, 'living alone as I do, in a rather out of the way part of the world, one has to have a hobby. There is, of course, woolwork, and Guides, and Welfare, and sketching, but my hobby is—and always

'Oh! I do—certainly.'
'I am glad. Well, that is all I have to say. I wash my hands of the whole affair.'

She leaned back and closed her eyes like one weary of this world. I thanked her and said good-bye.

On the doorstep, I ventured to ask Clara about her mistress's statement. 'It's quite true, sir, I heard a sneeze. And it wasn't an ordinary sneeze—not by any means.'

Nothing about a crime is ever ordinary. The shot was not an ordinary kind of shot. The sneeze was not a usual kind of sneeze. It was, I presume, a special murderer's sneeze. I asked the girl what time this had been, but she was very vague—some time between a quarter and half past six she thought. Anyway, 'it was before the mistress had the telephone call and was took bad.'

I asked her if she had heard a shot of any kind. And she said the shots had been something awful. After that, I placed very little credence in her statements.

I was just turning in at my own gate when I decided to pay a friend a visit.

Glancing at my watch, I saw that I had just time for it before taking Evensong. I went down the road to Haydock's house. He came out on the doorstep to meet me.

I noticed afresh how worried and haggard he looked. This business seemed to have aged him out of all knowledge.

'I'm glad to see you,' he said. 'What's the news?'

I told him the latest Stone development.

'A high class thief,' he commented. 'Well, that explains a lot of things. He'd read up his subject, but he made slips from time to time to me. Protheroe must have caught him out once. You remember the row they had. What do they think about the girl? Is she in it too?'

'Opinion as to that is undecided,' I said. 'For my own part, I think the girl is all right. She's such a prize idiot,' I added.

'Oh! I wouldn't say that. She's rather shrewd, is Miss Gladys Cram. A remarkably healthy specimen. Not likely to trouble members of my profession.'

that she was looking out for the fishmonger's boy—if he calls himself a boy—impudent young jackanapes, thinks because he's seventeen he can joke with all the girls. Anyway, as I say, she was standing at the gate and she heard a sneeze.'

'Yes,' I said waiting for more.

'That's all. I tell you she heard a sneeze. And don't start telling me I'm not so young as I once was and may have made a mistake, because it was Clara who heard it and she's only nineteen.'

'But,' I said, 'why shouldn't she have heard a sneeze?'

Mrs Price Ridley looked at me in obvious pity for my poorness of intellect.

'She heard a sneeze on the day of the murder at a time when there was no one in your house. Doubtless the murderer was concealed in the bushes waiting his opportunity. What you have to look for is a man with a cold in his head.'

'Or a sufferer from hay fever,' I suggested. 'But as a matter of fact, Mrs Price Ridley, I think that mystery has a very easy solution. Our maid, Mary, has been suffering from a severe cold in the head. In fact, her sniffing has tried us very much lately. It must have been her sneeze your maid heard.'

'It was a man's sneeze,' said Mrs Price Ridley firmly. 'And you couldn't hear your maid sneeze in your kitchen from our gate.'

'You couldn't hear anyone sneezing in the study from your gate,' I said. 'Or at least I very much doubt it.'

'I said the man might have been concealed in the shrubbery,' said Mrs Price Ridley. 'Doubtless when Clara had gone in, he effected an entrance by the front door.'

'Well, of course that's possible,' I said.

I tried not to make my voice consciously soothing, but I must have failed, for Mrs Price Ridley glared at me suddenly.

'I am accustomed not to be listened to, but I might mention also that to leave a tennis racquet carelessly flung down on the grass without a press completely ruins it. And tennis racquets are very expensive nowadays.'

There did not seem to be rhyme or reason in this flank attack. It bewildered me utterly.

'But perhaps you don't agree,' said Mrs Price Ridley.

has been—Human Nature. So varied—and so very fascinating. And, of course, in a small village, with nothing to distract one, one has such ample opportunity for becoming what I might call proficient in one's study. One begins to class people, quite definitely, just as though they were birds or flowers, group so and so, genus this, species that. Sometimes, of course, one makes mistakes, but less and less as time goes on. And then, too, one tests oneself. One takes a little problem—for instance the gill of pickled shrimps that amused dear Griselda so much—a quite unimportant mystery, but absolutely incomprehensible unless one solves it right. And then there was that matter of the changed cough drops, and the butcher's wife's umbrella—the last absolutely meaningless, unless on the assumption that the greengrocer was not behaving at all nicely with the chemist's wife—which, of course, turned out to be the case. It is so fascinating, you know, to apply one's judgment and find that one is right.'

'You usually are, I believe,' I said smiling.

'That, I am afraid, is what has made me a little conceited,' confessed Miss Marple. 'But I have always wondered whether, if some day a really big mystery came along, I should be able to do the same thing. I mean—just solve it correctly. Logically, it ought to be exactly the same thing. After all, a tiny working model of a torpedo is just the same as a real torpedo.'

'You mean it's all a question of relativity,' I said slowly. 'It should be—logically, I admit. But I don't know whether it really is.'

'Surely it must be the same,' said Miss Marple. 'The—what one used to call the factors at school—are the same. There's money, and mutual attraction between people of an—er—opposite sex—and there's queerness, of course—so many people are a little queer, aren't they?—in fact, most people are when you know them well. And normal people do such astonishing things sometimes, and abnormal people are sometimes so very sane and ordinary. In fact, the only way is to compare people with other people you have known or come across. You'd be surprised if you knew how very few distinct types there are in all.'

'You frighten me,' I said. 'I feel I'm being put under the microscope.'

'Of course, I wouldn't dream of saying any of this to Colonel Melchett—such an autocratic man, isn't he?—and poor Inspector Slack—well, he's exactly like the young lady in the boot shop who wants to sell you patent

leather because she's got it in your size, and doesn't take any notice of the fact that you want brown calf?

That really is a very good description of Slack.

'But you, Mr Clement, know, I'm sure, quite as much about the crime as Inspector Slack. I thought, if we could work together—'

'I wonder,' I said. 'I think each one of us in his secret heart fancies himself as Sherlock Holmes.'

Then I told her of the three summons I had received that afternoon. I told her of Anne's discovery of the picture with the slashed face. I also told her of Miss Crann's attitude at the police station, and I described Haydock's identification of the crystal I had picked up.

'Having found that myself, I finished up, 'I should like it to be important. But it's probably got nothing to do with the case.'

'I have been reading a lot of American detective stories from the library lately,' said Miss Marple, 'hoping to find them helpful.'

'Was there anything in them about picric acid?'

'I'm afraid not. I do remember reading a story once, though, in which a man was poisoned by picric acid and lanoline being rubbed on him as an ointment.'

'But as nobody has been poisoned here, that doesn't seem to enter into the question,' I said.

Then I took up my schedule and handed it to her.

'I've tried,' I said, 'to recapitulate the facts of the case as clearly as possible.'

'Oh! Vicar, you must not be so naughty,'
When she had recovered, she went on.

'A certain lady, and where do you think this certain lady was going? She turned into the Vicarage road, but before she did so, she looked up and down the road in a most peculiar way—to see if anyone she knew were noticing her, I imagine.'

'And the little bird? I inquired.

'Paying a visit to the fishmonger's—in the room over the shop.'

I now know where maids go on their days out. I know there is one place they never go if they can help—anywhere in the open air.

'And the time,' continued Miss Wetherby, leaning forward mysteriously, 'was just before six o'clock.'

'On which day?'

Miss Wetherby gave a little scream.

'The day of the murder, of course, didn't I say so?'

'I inferred it,' I replied. 'And the name of the lady?'

'Begins with an L,' said Miss Wetherby nodding her head several times. Feeling that I had got to the end of the information Miss Wetherby had to impart, I rose to my feet.

'You won't let the police cross-question me, will you?' said Miss Wetherby pathetically, as she clasped my hand in both of hers. 'I do shrink from publicity. And to stand up in Court!'

'In special cases,' I said, 'they let witnesses sit down.'

And I escaped.

There was still Mrs Price Ridley to see. That lady put me in my place at once.

'I will not be mixed up in any police court business,' she said firmly, after shaking my hand coldly. 'You understand that. On the other hand, having come across a circumstance which needs explaining, I think it should be brought to the notice of the authorities.'

'Does it concern Mrs Lestranger?' I asked.

'Why should it?' demanded Mrs Price Ridley coldly.

She had me at a disadvantage there.

'It's a very simple matter,' she continued. 'My maid, Clara, was standing at the front gate; she went down there for a minute or two—*she* says to get a breath of fresh air. Most unlikely, I should say. Much more probable

audience than the police. The clergy are supposed to give the benefit of the doubt to their parishioners.

I made no comment on the situation. I merely asked a question:

‘What time was this, Miss Hartnell?’

‘As far as I can remember,’ said Miss Hartnell, ‘it must have been close on six o’clock. I went straight home afterwards, and I got in about ten past six, and Mrs Protheroe came in somewhere round about the half hour, leaving Dr Stone and Mr Redding outside, and we talked about bulls. And all the time the poor Colonel lying murdered. It’s a sad world.’

‘It is sometimes a rather unpleasant one,’ I said.

I rose.

‘And that is all you have to tell me?’

‘I just thought it might be important.’

‘It might,’ I agreed.

And refusing to be drawn further, much to Miss Hartnell’s disappointment, I took my leave.

Miss Wetherby, whom I visited next, received me in a kind of flutter.

‘Dear Vicar, how truly kind. You’ve had tea? Really, you won’t? A cushion for your back? It is so kind of you to come round so promptly. Always willing to put yourself out for others.’

There was a good deal of this before we came to the point, and even then it was approached with a good deal of circumlocution.

‘You must understand that I heard this on the best authority.’

In St Mary Mead, the best authority is always somebody else’s servant.

‘You can’t tell me who told you?’

‘I promised, dear Mr Clement. And I always think a promise should be a sacred thing.’

She looked very solemn.

‘Shall we say a little bird told me? That is safe, isn’t it?’

I longed to say, ‘It’s damned silly.’ I rather wish I had. I should have liked to observe the effect on Miss Wetherby.

‘Well, this little bird told that she saw a certain lady who shall be nameless.’

‘Another kind of bird?’ I inquired.

To my great surprise Miss Wetherby went off into paroxysms of laughter and tapped me playfully on the arm saying:

Thursday 21st. inst.

MY SCHEDULE

12.30	P.M.	Colonel Protheroe alters his appointment from six to six fifteen. Overheard by half village very probably.
12.45	"	Pistol last seen in its proper place. (But this is doubtful as Mrs Archer had previously said she could not remember.)
5.30	"	(approx.) Colonel and Mrs Protheroe leave Old Hall for village in car.
5.30	"	Fake call put through to me from the North Lodge, Old Hall.
6.15	"	(or a minute or two earlier) Colonel Protheroe arrives at Vicarage. Is shown into study by Mary.
6.20	"	Mrs Protheroe comes along back lane and across garden to study window. Colonel Protheroe not visible.
6.29	"	Call from Lawrence Redding’s cottage put through to Mrs Price Ridley (according to exchange).
6.30–6.35	"	Shot heard (accepting telephone call time as correct). Lawrence Redding, Anne Protheroe, and Dr Stone’s evidence seem to point to its being earlier, but Mrs P. R. probably right.
6.45	"	Lawrence Redding arrives Vicarage and finds the body.
6.48	"	I meet Lawrence Redding.
6.49	"	Body discovered by me.
6.55	"	Haydock examines body.

Note: The only two people who have no kind of alibi for 6.30–6.35 are Miss Cram and Mrs Lestrangle. Miss Cram says she was at the barrow, but no confirmation. It seems reasonable, however, to dismiss her from case, as there seems nothing to connect her with it. Mrs Lestrangle left Dr Haydock’s house some time after six to keep

an appointment. Where was the appointment, and with whom? It could hardly have been with Colonel Protheroe, as he expected to be engaged with me. It is true that Mrs Lestrangle was near the spot at the time the crime was committed, but it seems doubtful what motive she could have had for murdering him. She did not gain by his death, and the Inspector's theory of blackmail I cannot accept. Mrs Lestrangle is not that kind of woman. Also, it seems unlikely that she should have got hold of Lawrence Redding's pistol.

'Very clear,' said Miss Marple nodding her head in approval. 'Very clear, indeed. Gentlemen always make such excellent memoranda.'

'You agree with what I have written?' I asked.

'Oh! yes—you have put it all beautifully.'

I asked her the question then that I had been meaning to put all along. 'Miss Marple,' I said. 'Who do you suspect? You once said that there were seven people.'

'Quite that, I should think,' said Miss Marple absently. 'I expect every one of us suspects someone different. In fact, one can see they do.'

She didn't ask me whom I suspected.

'The point is,' she said, 'that one must provide an explanation for everything. Each thing has got to be explained away satisfactorily. If you have a theory that fits every fact—well, then it must be the right one. But that's extremely difficult. If it wasn't for that note—'

'The note?' I said surprised.

'Yes, you remember, I told you. That note has worried me all along. It's wrong, somehow.'

'Surely,' I said, 'that is explained now. It was written at 6.35, and another hand—the murderer's—put the misleading 6.20 at the top. I think that is clearly established.'

'But even then,' said Miss Marple, 'it's all wrong.'

'But why?'

'Listen—' Miss Marple leant forward eagerly. 'Mrs Protheroe passed my garden, as I told you, and she went as far as the study window and she looked in and she didn't see Colonel Protheroe.'

'Because he was writing at the desk,' I said.

'I've been given to understand,' went on Miss Hartnell, turning rather red, 'that Mrs Lestrangle gives out that she was at home all the time—that she didn't answer the door because—well, because she didn't choose. Such airs and graces. I only called as a matter of duty, and to be treated like that!'

'She has been ill,' I said mildly.

'Ill? Fiddlesticks. You're too unworldly. Mr Clement. There's nothing the matter with that woman. Too ill to attend the inquest indeed! Medical certificate from Dr Haydock! She can wind him round her little finger; everyone knows that. Well, where was I?'

I didn't quite know. It is difficult with Miss Hartnell to know where narrative ends and vituperation begins.

'Oh! about calling on her that afternoon. Well, it's fiddlesticks to say she was in the house. She wasn't. I know.'

'How can you possibly know?'

Miss Hartnell's face turned a little redder. In someone less truculent, her demeanour might have been called embarrassed.

'I'd knocked and rung,' she explained. 'Twice. If not three times. And it occurred to me suddenly that the bell might be out of order.'

She was, I was glad to note, unable to look me in the face when saying this. The same builder builds all our houses, and the bells he installs are always clearly audible when standing on the mat outside the front door. Both Miss Hartnell and I knew this perfectly well, but I suppose decencies have to be preserved.

'Yes?' I murmured.

'I didn't want to push my card through the letter box. That would seem so rude, and, whatever I am, I am never rude.'

She made this amazing statement without a tremor.

'So I thought I would just go round the house and—and tap on the window pane,' she continued unblushingly. 'I went all round the house and looked in at all the windows, but there was no one in the house at all.'

I understood her perfectly. Taking advantage of the fact that the house was empty, Miss Hartnell had given unbridled rein to her curiosity and had gone round the house, examining the garden and peering in at all the windows to see as much as she could of the interior. She had chosen to tell her story to me, believing that I should be a more sympathetic and lenient